CHAPTER 11

MAHATMA GANDHI AND THE NATIONALIST MOVEMENT

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master Mahatma Gandhi's transformation of the Indian national movement: South African satyagraha, Non-Cooperation Movement (1920-22), the historic Salt March to Dandi (1930), and the Quit India Movement (1942).

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Return from South Africa and Mass Base Transformation:** Returned to India in January 1915; transformed elite Congress politics into a mass nationalist movement through Champaran (1917), Kheda (1918), and Ahmedabad mill strike using Satyagraha (truth-force).

• **Non-Cooperation and Khilafat Movement (1920-22):** Linked redressal of Jallianwala Bagh massacre (1919) and Khilafat grievances; boycotted colonial schools, courts, titles, and foreign cloth; suspended abruptly in Feb 1922 following Chauri Chaura violence.

• **Salt March and Civil Disobedience (1930-31):** Marched 240 miles from Sabarmati to Dandi (March-April 1930) to manufacture salt; symbolized universal resistance against an unjust colonial tax; led to Gandhi-Irwin Pact and Second Round Table Conference.

• **Quit India Movement (1942) and Independence:** Launched in August 1942 with the call 'Do or Die'; mass underground and peasant rebellion amidst wartime repression; culminated in 1947 independence and tragic Partition.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Gandhian Mass Transformation} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Champaran (1917)} \rightarrow \text{Rowlatt Satyagraha (1919)} \rightarrow \text{Non-Cooperation (1920)}$$

Evolution from Local Agrarian Struggle to Pan-Indian Mass Politics

$$\text{Dandi Salt March Dynamics} \Longleftrightarrow 240 \text{ Miles} \rightarrow 24 \text{ Days} \rightarrow \text{Defiance of Colonial Salt Monopoly}$$

Symbolic Catalyst of the 1930 Civil Disobedience Movement

$$\text{Satyagraha Dialectic} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Satya (Truth)} + \text{Ahimsa (Non-Violence)} + \text{Self-Suffering}$$

Foundational Moral and Strategic Paradigm of Gandhian Struggle

$$\text{Quit India Resolute Call (August 1942)} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Karenge ya Marenge (Do or Die)} \rightarrow \text{Total National Freedom}$$

Final Decisive Phase of the Indian Freedom Movement

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Mahatma Gandhi suspended the Non-Cooperation Movement in February 1922 because of the violent Chauri Chaura incident (where peasants burnt a police station, killing 22 policemen).

• **Alert:** Salt was chosen as the symbol of Civil Disobedience because salt was an indispensable necessity used equally by rich and poor; the British tax on it was the most oppressive domestic imposition.

• **Alert:** Lord Mountbatten was the last Viceroy of British India who announced the Partition plan on 3 June 1947.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. How did Mahatma Gandhi transform the Indian national movement into a broad-based mass struggle? [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Living and Dressing like Ordinary People:** Wore a simple khadi dhoti, discarded Western attire, spoke in vernacular Hindustani, and traveled by third-class railway carriages, forging deep emotional identification with the poor. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **2. Championing Grassroots Peasant Issues:** Led struggles of indigo farmers in Champaran (1917), peasants in Kheda (1918), and mill workers in Ahmedabad, bringing peasants and workers into nationalist politics. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **3. Constructive Program:** Combined political agitation with social reforms: promotion of charkha and khadi, removal of untouchability, Hindu-Muslim unity, and village self-reliance. **[1 Mark]**

2. Explain the causes, program, and sudden suspension of the Non-Cooperation Movement (1920-22). [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Causes:** Anger over the repressive Rowlatt Act, the horrific Jallianwala Bagh massacre (April 1919), and betrayal of the Khilafat promise to Indian Muslims. **[1 Mark]**

• **Program:** Boycott of government schools, colleges, law courts, legislative councils, surrender of British titles, and picketing of foreign cloth and liquor shops. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Suspension:** In February 1922, a violent mob set fire to a police station at Chauri Chaura (Gorakhpur), killing 22 policemen; Gandhi immediately called off the movement, declaring that Indians were not yet trained in strict non-violence. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Why did Mahatma Gandhi choose 'Salt' as the central symbol of protest for the Civil Disobedience Movement? Describe the Dandi March. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Why Salt:** Salt was a basic necessity of life consumed equally by every Indian; the colonial state held a monopoly over its manufacture and collected tax on it, symbolizing colonial oppression entering every Indian kitchen. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **The March:** On 12 March 1930, Gandhi began walking from Sabarmati Ashram with 78 chosen volunteers, covering 240 miles to the coastal village of Dandi in 24 days. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Inauguration of Civil Disobedience:** On 6 April 1930, Gandhi picked up a handful of natural salt on Dandi beach, technically breaking the salt law and signaling millions across India to manufacture contraband salt. **[1 Mark]**

4. Discuss the significance of the Quit India Movement of 1942. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **The Call:** Launched in August 1942 in Bombay following the failure of the Cripps Mission, with Gandhi giving the historic mantra 'Do or Die' (Karenge ya Marenge). **[1 Mark]**

• **Mass Participation:** Entire senior Congress leadership was arrested on day one, sparking a spontaneous nationwide rebellion; students and peasants sabotaged railway lines, post offices, and cut telegraph wires. **[1 Mark]**

• **Significance:** Demonstrated that the British had completely lost moral authority to rule India, making independence inevitable after World War II. **[1 Mark]**

5. State two terms of the Gandhi-Irwin Pact signed in March 1931. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Term 1:** The British government agreed to release all political prisoners not convicted of violence and permit peaceful picketing. **[1 Mark]**

• **Term 2:** The Congress agreed to suspend the Civil Disobedience Movement and participate in the Second Round Table Conference in London. **[1 Mark]**

6. When and by whom was Mahatma Gandhi assassinated? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Date and Place:** Assassinated on 30 January 1948 at Birla House in New Delhi during his evening prayer meeting. **[1 Mark]**

• **Assassinated By:** Nathuram Godse, a Hindu extremist who opposed Gandhi's steadfast commitment to Hindu-Muslim unity. **[1 Mark]**